

BATTLE ROYALE Wayandu BJP candidate and state unit chief K. Surendran with Union minister Smriti Irani at a party roadshow

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THE BJP'S CHOICE IN PATHANAMTHITTA, ANIL ANTONY, REVEALS A KEY STRATEGY: THE ATTEMPTED ENTENTE CORDIALE WITH THE CHRISTIAN COMMUNITY HERE

Anil Antony. Call it a double inversion, for he's the son of long-time Gandhi family loyalist and former Union minister/CM A.K. Antony. The choice revealed a key strategic component: the BJP's attempted entente cordiale with the Christian community, 18 per cent of Kerala's population. This has a backstory. For roughly the decade of UPA rule, coinciding with the two CM stints here of the late Oommen Chandy, the Congress had acquired a reputation of being a "pro-Christian" party. That had accelerated a saffron-ward drift among Nairs, the formerly landowning caste that covers some 15-20 per cent of Kerala's demographic, a significant chunk of the 54.7 per cent Hindu population. Traditionally antagonistic towards the Left since the mid-20th century land reforms, the Nairs had largely sought refuge in the Congress-led UDF before saffron's arrival tempted them. The Sabarimala controversy pretty much consummated the Nair-saffron matrimony even as the Congress flailed about trying to undo perceptions with soft Hindutva.

The caste vanguard in place, the BJP is looking for some crop diversity with the Christians. Not that the soil is entirely infertile. *The Kerala Story* controversy played out big time locally when, a day before Doordarshan, the Idukki diocese of the Syro-Malabar Church, a prominent Catholic wing, screened it for high-schoolers to "create awareness about love relationships and its consequences and dangers". Days later, a series of counter moves showed more sides to the Kerala story. The St. Joseph's church in Kochi, under the same Syro-Malabar Catholic church, screened the documentary, *Manipur - The Cry of the Oppressed*, saying "facts, not an agenda" should prevail. A number of others have also come down on the Idukki diocese's act, with one revered metropolitan commenting that churches should be screening movies about love, not hate. The mood was summed up best on Eid day, when the Nicholas memorial CSI church in Manjeri, Malappuram, opened its grounds so that the Muslim faithful could say their prayers.

Still, the concept of love jihad has a Kerala genesis and sections of the Church have always been at risk of passing a paternity test on that. Thus comes about the miracle that, as an echo of modern-day global Crusades, some Christians here may be willing to overlook any crisis of secularism elsewhere in India and vote saffron. At least, the BJP is banking on that—in Pathanamthitta and in Thrissur, for the portly superstar Suresh Gopi.

As for the Left, its icon Pinarayi has mastered the art of managing local flux, as evidenced in two back-to-back assembly poll vote percentages in the mid-40s. "Pinarayi is a great political mathematician. He was very vocal against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act and the Manipur violence. With minorities having a decisive role in Kerala, he is building his safety net," says former Congressman and now state NCP chief P.C. Chacko.

The CPI(M) cadre, with the 22 per cent OBC Ezhava population not an insignificant part of that, is intact too. The Left, though, sometimes has the look and feel of a regional party these days—far from the days when legendary Communist leader A.K. Gopalan became India's first Leader of the Opposition in the 1952 Lok Sabha. So its resolve to keep Kerala 'BJP-*mukt*' has acquired slightly nativist tones. But with the saffron dough rising—2019 saw its candidates poll 200,000-300,000 votes—will the cracks on the ramparts be big enough this time? ■